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Market Trends Report · Week 2, June 2026 (Jun 8–14)

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Shrinking market

3 growth axes

Channel playbook

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Feature A shrinking liquor market — where is the money going? Volume falls, but unit price rises

CONTENTS

Contents & At a Glance

- 01** **Market Diagnosis — Volume Shrinks, Money Moves**
Four declining indicators—shipments, per-capita consumption, drinking frequency—in big visuals
- 02** **Where the Money Goes — Growth vs. Decline Map**
Growing vs. shrinking categories chart + category share donut
- 03** **Growth Axis ① Highball · RTD — A Light Drink**
CVS share 8.3%→38.6% explosive growth; instant new menu via kits
- 04** **Growth Axis ② Non-Alc · Low-ABV — Drinking Without Getting Drunk**
+9%/yr growth, on-premise gap — room for wholesalers to lead
- 05** **Growth Axis ③ Premium · Taste — Less, but Better**
Record growth of Japanese sake & beer + whisky/natural wine driving unit price
- 06** **Channel Sales Proposals — Hotels / Restaurants / Bars**
Sewang's tailored proposals by channel + direct contacts
- 07** **Maximizing Store Sales — Sewang's 6 Proposals**
Sewang executes together via products, kits, and consulting
- 08** **About Sewang Sangsa & 13 Sales Contacts**
Full-line liquor wholesaler for Seoul/Gyeonggi hotels–restaurants · contacts by area

This Issue in One Line

▲ Structural shift

The overall market is shrinking, yet within it the money is moving toward three axes—**Highball, Non-Alc, and Premium**. The wholesaler's answer is not "defending volume" but **seizing growth axes + proposing menu solutions**.

Market Diagnosis — Volume Shrinks, Money Moves

Total shipments and drinking frequency are clearly declining, yet within the same market, sales are migrating by unit price, category, and channel.

Four Declining Indicators — Volume and Frequency Clearly Fall

▼
11%

Domestic liquor shipments

4.07M→3.61M kL
(2015→2023)

▼
18%

Per-capita annual alcohol

9.81L→8.07L (2015→2021)

▼
12.4%

Annual drinking occasions

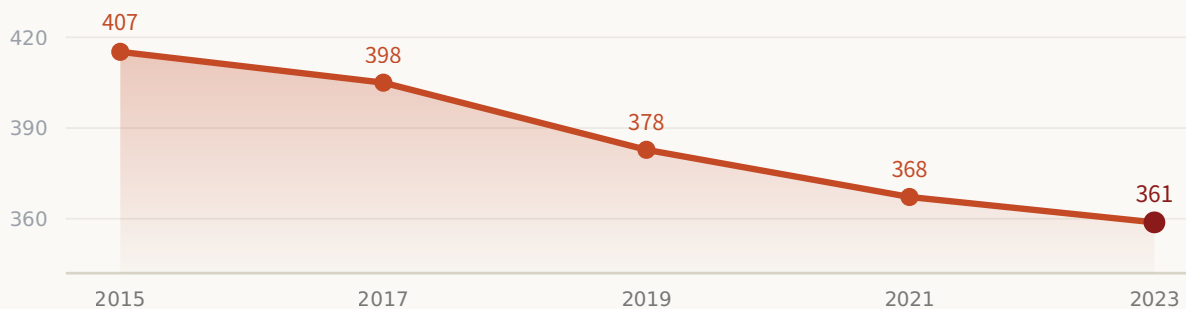
32.1M→28.1M
('24→'25)

▼
10.4%

Monthly drinking payers

20.3M→18.2M ppl
('24→'25)

Domestic Liquor Shipments Trend (10k kL)



Eight straight years of decline as weak domestic demand, fading company-dinner/second-round culture, and the spread of moderation overlap. 2017/2019 midpoints are trend interpolations.

KEY

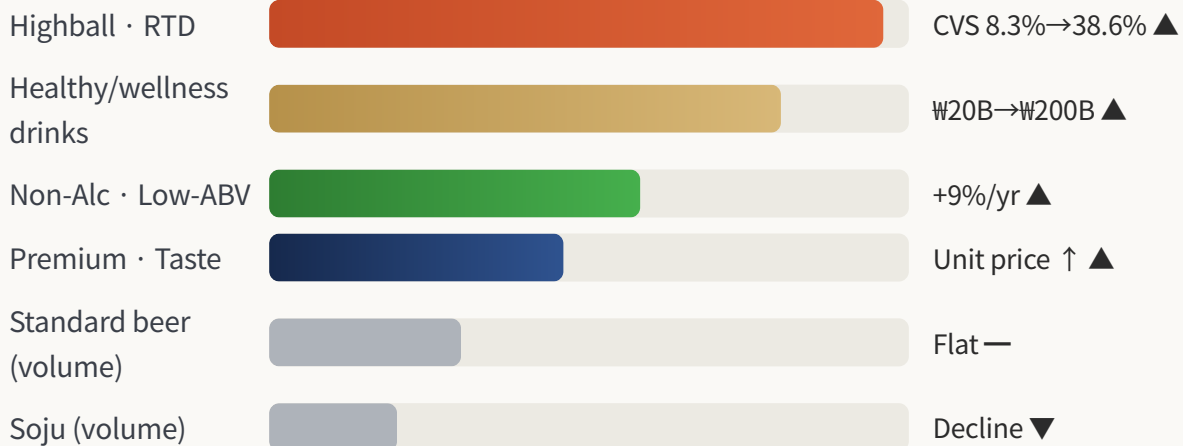
The hardest hit are "volume" products like soju and case beer. But that is only half the market—as the next page shows, there are clearly cells that are growing over the same period.

Sources: NTS & Korea Liquor Industry Assn. shipment stats · Statistics Korea per-capita alcohol estimates · fintech-payment-based drinking-frequency analysis (2025) · Samil PwC "The Age of Enjoying Alcohol" · ※ Some figures are estimates and may vary by source/period.

Where the Money Goes — Growth vs. Decline Map

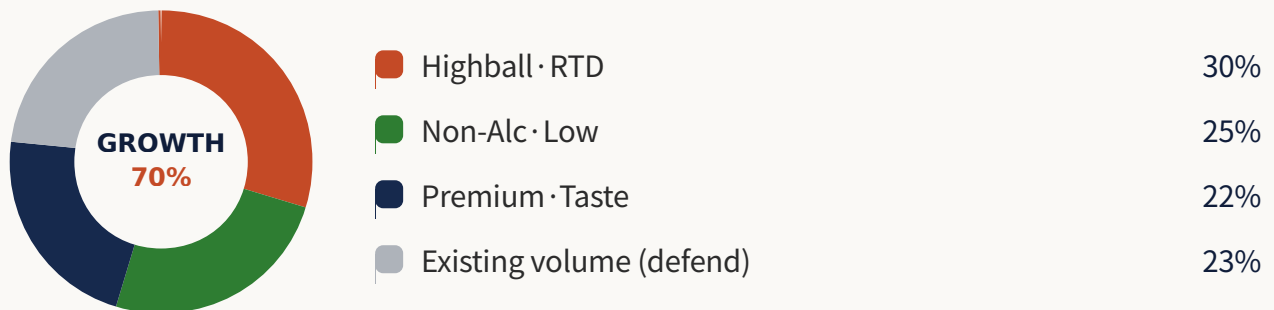
As "drink till you drop" fades, "less, lighter, and better" consumption takes its place, reshuffling sales across categories.

Category Growth Direction



※ Sources/criteria differ by category, so bar lengths show "growth direction," not absolute comparison. Highball is share within CU CVS imported-liquor sales.

2026 Store Sales Center of Gravity — Where to Push



Sewang's proposed center of gravity to grow with partners—about 70% on the 3 growth axes, about 30% on maintaining existing volume items.

How to Read It — One Trend, Three Faces

▲ Diverging

As binge drinking fades, consumption splits three ways—① lighter, lower ABV (**Highball · RTD**), ② alcohol removed (**Non-Alc · Low-ABV**), ③ less but better (**Premium · Taste**). For a wholesaler, that means all three axes can be proposed to a single store.

Sources: CU CVS imported-liquor sales mix · Euromonitor non-alcoholic market outlook · reports on E-mart expanding low-ABV/non-alc lineup · Kuki News "Lighter Liquor Consumption," 2026-02-19 · ※ Shares/allocations reflect industry consensus and Sewang proposals and may vary.

Highball · RTD — The Explosion of "A Light Drink"

Ready-To-Drink products are driving new growth, lowering the whisky entry barrier and absorbing demand from those in their 20s–30s.

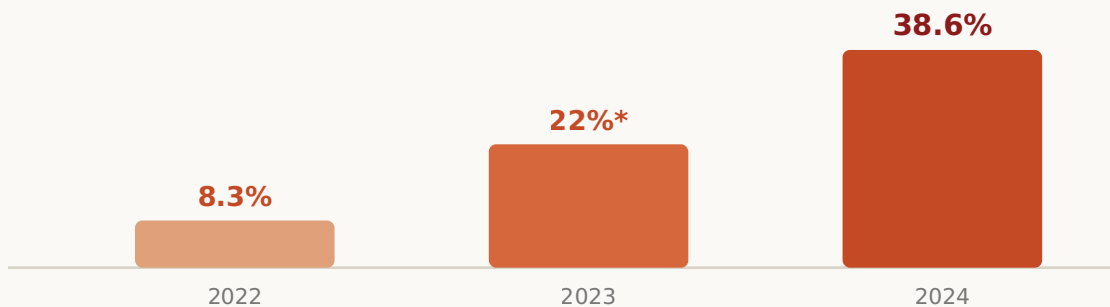
HIGHBALL SHARE IN CVS IMPORTED LIQUOR

8.3% →
38.6%

2022→2024, about 4.6× · 65% of highball consumption is by people in their 20s–30s

- ↑ **Lower barrier ↓** — letting people enjoy whisky "by the glass" rather than "by the bottle" brings in new drinkers
- ★ **Drives check size** — paired with izakaya/sushi-sakaba, it adds revenue per table
- ✳ **Easy to menu-ize** — with just whisky + tonic + glass, any store gets an instant new menu

Highball Share Growth (within CVS imported-liquor sales, %)



* The 2023 value is a trend interpolation between 2022 and 2024. Source: CU CVS imported-liquor sales mix.

Sewang's Proposal — Instant New Menu via Highball Kits

▲ Immediate

① **Highball kit bundle** — whisky (e.g., Kakubin) + tonic + lemon + dedicated glass, bundled so a store can launch a highball menu right away and raise check size · ② **RTD canned highball** to boost fast-turning pocha/hof sales · ③ **Non-alc highball** to capture drivers and daytime guests. Sewang supplies it as a kit.

Sources: CU CVS imported-liquor sales mix · Kuki News 2026-02-19 · Insight Korea mixology insight · ✳ Yearly and generational shares are estimates based on reports/consensus.

Non-Alc · Low-ABV — "Sober" Consumption

Driven by the "sober-curious" trend, it is moving from substitute to standalone category. On-premise is still empty—big room to lead.

KOREA HEALTHY/NON-ALC LIQUOR MARKET

₩20B →
₩200B

2021→2025 outlook, about 10× · non-alc/low-alc +9% CAGR (through 2026)



On-premise gap — the home market is saturated (Cass 0.0 etc.), but stores have almost no lineup

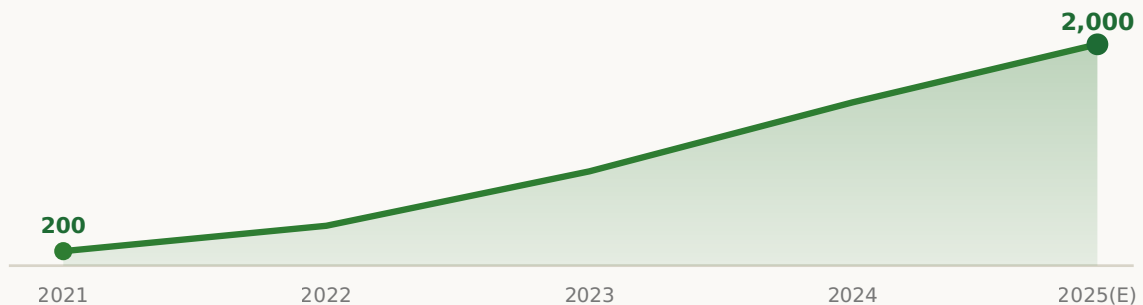


Wider audience — additionally captures drivers, expectant mothers, dieters, and daytime guests



More variety — E-mart expands low-ABV/non-alc to 30+ SKUs in 2026

Healthy/Non-Alc Liquor Market Size (₩100M)



Source: Euromonitor/industry outlook. Intermediate years are trend interpolations; 2025 is a forecast (E).

Sewang's Proposal — Go "Bottled" for On-Trade

▲ Differentiate

① **Stock it bottled** — bottled non-alc (Heineken 0.0, Asahi Zero, etc.), not cans, differentiates from the home market (mostly cans) and lifts **check size and premium feel** · ② **Co-display** — placing bottled non-alc next to summer lagers raises both check size and turnover · ③ **Hotel/dining mocktails** — non-alc cocktails/spritzes reach healthy-pleasure guests too. Sewang supplies the bottled line.

Sources: Euromonitor non-alc outlook · EBN “Shrinking drinking—breaking through via non-alc/overseas” · reports on E-mart lineup expansion · ※ Market size/growth are estimates and may vary by source/period.

Premium · Taste — "Less, but Better"

Even as volume falls, the price per bottle rises. Japanese sake and beer in particular are leading the premium channel with record growth.

CONSUMPTION PARADIGM SHIFT

Volume ↓ Price ↑

Not "more" but "right"—whisky, natural wine, and premium sake create high-value sales



Scarcity premium — consumers gladly pay for limited editions, single casks, and natural wine



Storytelling — origin, maker, and tasting notes become menu competitiveness



Channel fit — ideal for hotels, fine dining, omakase, and wine bars

★ Spotlight — Japanese Sake & Beer Are Driving Premium Growth

Even as imported liquor stalls overall, **Japanese beer and sake are growing at record pace, alone**. A weak yen, the end of "No Japan," and an izakaya boom have combined to make them the key driver of the premium channel.

▲ 41.6%

Japanese share of imported beer
Jan–Apr 2026 (about 3× of 2023)

▲ +17.3%

Japanese beer import value growth
2025 all-time high (\$79.15M)

▲ #1 & #3

Asahi #1 · Sapporo #3
Sapporo share +3%p, #1 growth

SEWANG

Stocking the full lineup of major Japanese beers—**Asahi Super Dry, Sapporo, Kirin Ichiban, Suntory Premium Malt's, Yebisu, Orion**—plus **premium sake** (Dassai, Hakutsuru, Kubota) raises check size at izakaya, sushi-sakaba, and dining venues. Premium + healthy-pleasure launches like Sapporo "Draft 70" (–70% sugar/purine) sell out early, so Sewang secures priority volume for you.

Sewang's Proposal — Small-Lot, Many-SKU Curation

▲ Defend price

① **Japanese sake & beer package** — Asahi, Sapporo, Kirin, Suntory, Yebisu + premium sake, proposed as izakaya/dining bundles · ② **Story package** — whisky and natural wine supplied with tasting notes and pairing guides · ③ **Staff training support** — Sewang provides pairing/serving guides for store staff to build regulars.

Sources: Korea Customs beer import stats (2025, Jan–Apr 2026) · Hankyung “Japanese beer imports hit record,” 2026-05-05 · Herald Economy “Japan share tops 41%” · EBN/JoongAng Economy News “Sapporo #1 growth” · Hankyung “Sake selling on its own,” 2025-10-31 · Insight Korea mixology insight · ※ Figures are report/customs-based and may vary by period.

Channel Attack Strategy

Sewang's tailored sales proposals by channel — Hotels/Fine dining / Restaurants/Izakaya / Bars/Pocha + direct contacts



CHANNEL 01

Hotels/Fine Dining — Defend with "Unit Price"

A channel where guest counts fall but per-table check size rises. The weapon is **curation and scarcity**, not volume. We supply story-rich whisky, natural wine, and premium sake in small-lot variety, and propose a **non-alc wine/mocktail/non-alc spritz** pairing line for healthy-pleasure guests.

Sewang — we co-design seasonal pairing menus and curate premium + non-alc together (Contacts: VP Han-woo Lee / Managing Dir. Seung-il Son)



CHANNEL 02

Restaurants/Izakaya — Create with "New Menus"

The fastest channel to apply growth axes. Build an instant new menu with a **highball kit**, and raise check size via sake/dachi pairings. Adding one non-alc beer to the regular menu captures drivers and daytime demand—**offsetting fewer guests with menu variety**.

Sewang — we build new menus with highball kits + bottled non-alc + Japanese sake packages (Contacts: Exec. Dir. Chang-soo Lim / Dir. Hyun-yong Chae & Hwan Kim)



CHANNEL 03

Bars/Pocha/Hof — Turnover via "Season & Bundles"

In the summer peak (Jun–Aug), draft/bottled beer turnover surges. Offset declining soju volume with **summer lager + non-alc co-display** and **RTD bundles**. With healthy/low-calorie demand layered on, stores carrying one non-alc/low-ABV row absorb extra guests.

Sewang — we prepare summer-lager pre-orders + non-alc/RTD co-display sets (Contacts: GMs Kwang-seok Yoo, Jong-hwan Bae, Hyun-woo Sung)

OUR PROMISE

Channels differ, but the core proposal is the same — **switch shrinking volume items to the 3 growth axes (Highball, Non-Alc, Premium) and sales rise**. Sewang partners through products, menus, and promotion—not just delivery. New-store intel and SNS trends are also provided by Deputy GM Hyun-woong Hwang.

Sources: analysis from PARTs 01–05 of this report + Sewang channel/partner operations data. Contact-area assignments may change—calling HQ (02-2203-5311) first is recommended.

Maximizing Store Sales — Sewang's 6 Proposals

Six proposals to grow store sales even in a shrinking market. Sewang executes them with you via products, kits, and consulting.

1

Introduce a Bottled Non-Alc Line

Putting bottled non-alc on the menu wins new **driver/daytime/dieter guests**. It differentiates from the home market (cans) and lifts check size. Sewang supplies the bottled line.

Heineken 0.0
bottle

Asahi
Zero

Bottled non-
alc

2

Instant New Menu via Highball Kit

Just stock a whisky + tonic + glass **kit** for an instant highball menu—check size rises. Sewang delivers the kit.

Kakubin

RTD
can

Dedicated
glass

3

Raise Unit Price with Premium

Stocking story-rich whisky, Japanese sake, and natural wine lifts the **price per bottle**. Sewang curates in small-lot variety.

Single
cask

Natural
wine

Premium
sake

4

Summer Lager + Non-Alc Side by Side

Placing **non-alc/RTD** next to summer lagers raises both turnover and check size. Sewang proposes it as a set.

Draft pre-
order

Co-
display

5

Trend & Menu Consulting

Which menu draws which guests—Sewang co-designs it with **weekly reports and pairing guides**.

Weekly
report

Menu
design

6

New-Product Launch & Promo Support

When you bring in new/seasonal menus, Sewang supports **promo materials, staff training, and launch**. Skip the trial-and-error and just take the sales.

Launch
support

Staff
training

Our Promise — We Grow Sales Together

▲ Grow together

Piling on volume just because the market shrinks backfires. **Shift your center of gravity to growing categories** and store sales rise. Sewang stays with you to the end through **products, kits, consulting, and promotion**—this is how stores and Sewang grow together in a shrinking market.

About Sewang Sangsa & Sales Contacts

From Seoul/Gyeonggi hotels to restaurants — a full-line liquor wholesale partner · founded 1978 · a 13-person sales team

Sewang Sangsa Co., Ltd.

Full-line liquor distribution to Seoul/Gyeonggi hotels, restaurants, and bars · founded 1978 · this report is for distribution to external partners

CHANNELS

Hotels · Fine dining · Korean pubs · Izakaya · Pocha
· Clubs · Lounge bars

CATEGORIES

Beer (HiteJinro · OB · Lotte) · Non-alc · Imported beer
· Whisky · Wine · Sake · Makgeolli · Soju ·
Traditional liquor

SERVICES

Weekly market-trends report · new-store sourcing ·
partner SNS intelligence · new-product promo/
launch support · pairing consulting

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Exec. Dir.	Jung-eon Park	010-3286-9489	Sales lead · report publishing
Mng. Dir.	Seung-il Son	010-7539-3535	Seoul Yongsan · Hannam · Itaewon · Samgakji
Director	Won-cheol Lee	010-3354-2101	Seoul Gangbuk · Jongno · Jung-gu
Director	Hyun-yong Chae	010-8889-3057	Seoul Seongdong · Seongsu · Wangsimni
Director	Hwan Kim	010-4789-3282	Seoul Mapo · Seodaemun · Yeonnam · Hongdae
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